CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

BRINGING HOME THE MAHARAJA

A Passion for Flying

When planes are discussed, even today, Ratan's eyes brighten. Flying is a passion with him. It is a childhood obsession that in his case has defied age. Whenever he has had a chance, he has tried everything possible to fly a plane.

The most interesting instance was when he refused to go to Bhutan to visit a Tata Power project in 2007 unless he could fly his aircraft to Paro International Airport—where landing requires extraordinary skills since the air strip is cantilevered 2,245 metres above sea level between mountains. However, Ratan got his way and was spied engaging in aviation conversation with his co-pilot when he landed and took off, doing so with the ease of a veteran.

He shared his passion for daredevil flying with JRD. In a preface to a book about JRD and Air India, Ratan recalled how their common weakness for flying brought them closer. He said: 'Whenever he (JRD) visited Jamshedpur, he always made time to log an hour or two and he often flew with me in the company aircraft which I used to fly while I was there. Our bond grew thereafter. I became close to him in the matters relating to the Tata Group and he often shared with me his pride and sometimes his frustrations in Air India, which he loved so much and on which he spent an enormous amount of time.'

Air India meant a lot to JRD. Even though he had established some of the most important and successful Tata enterprises, including TELCO and Tata Chemicals, Air India, which he had started in 1932, had an emotional pull for him.